Clio

Overcoming Resistance to Achieve Results:

A Comprehensive Guide to Driving Change at Your Mid-Sized Firm

Doug Brown, JD, Summit Success LLC

Doug Brown is a highly regarded law firm leadership coach dedicated to helping legal professionals simplify their operations, lead with confidence, and build sustainable practices so they can enjoy a more fulfilling professional and personal life. Drawing upon his extensive and diverse background as a recovering lawyer, with experience in both in-house and private practice settings, and as a former Bar Association executive director, Doug brings a unique and practical perspective to the challenges faced by law firm leaders. His tenure in academia, where he taught leadership, innovation, and entrepreneurship in an MBA program, provided him with a deeper understanding of the science behind effective change management, culminating in his expertise on the "Change Equation."

Throughout his career, Doug has focused on overcoming resistance to change, recognizing the particular mindset and assumptions within the legal profession that can often hinder progress. He now leverages his experience and frameworks, such as the Change Equation, to guide law firms through strategic transformations, helping them adopt a "beginner's mind" and navigate the complexities of implementing new systems and processes. As a sought-after speaker and consultant, Doug offers valuable insights and practical tools, including resources on after-action reviews, leadership styles, delegation, feedback, and emotional intelligence (as referenced during the webinar). His goal is to empower lawyers to focus on their legal expertise while building effective and thriving firms, supported by sound management principles and strategic advisors.

Ashley Duffy, Clio

Ashley Duffy is a Senior Demand Generation Manager at Clio, a recognized leader in legal technology. With extensive experience driving strategic growth for mid-sized law firms, Ashley is an expert in helping firms navigate the complexities of change management and digital transformation. Her deep understanding of the legaltech landscape enables her to craft tailored solutions that enhance firm operations, streamline client services, and drive long-term growth. By blending data-driven strategies with a keen understanding of the unique challenges faced by mid-sized firms, Ashley helps legal professionals leverage technology to optimize efficiency and improve client outcomes. Passionate about empowering firms to evolve in an ever-changing industry, she is a trusted voice for those looking to adopt innovative solutions for sustained success.

Why change is so hard—and how to make it easier

Resistance to change is a natural human response—one that is particularly pronounced within the legal profession. Understanding the roots of resistance is essential for successfully navigating change management and fostering a culture of transformation.

The hidden power of legal mental models

Lawyers are trained to rely on precedent, standards and mental models to solve problems, reduce risk and maintain high standards. These models, grounded in tradition, also create inertia and resistance to new ways of operating. Lawyers tend to favor the familiar, often sticking to established practices—even when those practices are inefficient. This preference for the "devil they know" is driven by the fear of the unknown and the discomfort that comes with challenging established norms. This resistance is not simply about reluctance to change, but a fear of losing the stability and certainty that tradition provides.

Escape "shiny object syndrome" with strategic intent

Today's legal leaders are increasingly called upon to adopt new technologies to solve problems and enhance the effectiveness of their practices. Few lawyers have a strategic framework for evaluating new initiatives, which means that many fall into the trap of "shiny object syndrome." This occurs when firms implement changes that don't align with their long-term goals, resulting in change fatigue and wasted resources. To avoid this, it's essential to have a clear process for evaluating any new initiative. Before diving into a change, ask: "How does this align with our strategy? How will it deliver measurable ROI?" Change should ultimately lead to a transformation—one that benefits the firm and its clients in a tangible way.

Overcome perfectionism, people-pleasing, and the fear of mistakes

The legal profession often attracts individuals with a strong drive for perfectionism and a desire to meet the expectations of both clients and colleagues. FUD (Fear, Uncertainty, and Doubt) represents a set of anxieties that contribute to resistance to change, particularly when outcomes are unknown or unclear. FUD is often a hidden cause of hesitation and delay in decision-making.

Fear of making mistakes—whether in delivering services or adopting new ways of working—is a common blocker to change. Leaders can overcome this by reframing mistakes as opportunities for growth, not failures. Creating a safe environment for experimentation, where individuals can take calculated risks without fear of judgment, is key to encouraging change.

The Change Equation: A formula for transformation:

The Change Equation[1] provides a critical framework for overcoming resistance:

Dissatisfaction (D) x Vision (V) x First Steps (F) > Resistance (R)

This formula illustrates that all three factors must work in harmony to effectively counter resistance. It's a multiplication equation, so if any factor is zero, or negative, then the product will be zero or negative and resistance will win—and meaningful change will not happen.

1 Dig into dissatisfaction (D)

To initiate change, it's essential to identify and articulate the pain points and inefficiencies that exist within the current state. Leaders should actively engage with their teams to uncover frustrations, asking practical questions such as:

- "What's the most frustrating part of your day right now? Why?"
- "If you could fix one thing, what would it be? Why?"

Common pain points in law firms include time-consuming manual processes, redundant data entry, and client dissatisfaction with outdated communication methods. By clearly identifying these issues, you can create a sense of urgency for change.

2 Craft a compelling vision (V)

A strong vision provides a clear and motivating picture of what the future could look like after the change is implemented. It answers the "why"—articulating the benefits of the change for the team, the clients, and the firm as a whole. The most effective visions are co-created and fostered through regular communication, one-on-one meetings, and small group discussions. If your team cannot readily explain your vision, and find motivation in it, then it isn't effective. Engaging people in the vision-building process encourages buy-in and fosters a sense of ownership. For example, if dissatisfaction stems from inefficient billing processes, the vision could focus on increased productivity, faster payments, and improved client satisfaction—and most importantly, the transformation the team members will experience when the change is fully implemented.

[1] Richard Beckhard, Reuben T. Harris, Organizational Transitions: Managing Complex Change, 2nd ed. (Reading, MA: Addison-Wesley, 1987).

K.D. Dannemiller, Whole-Scale Change: Unleashing the Magic in Organizations (San Francisco: Berrett-Koehler Publishers, 2000).

3 Taking meaningful first steps (F)

Initiating change doesn't require having all the steps identified. You simply need to identify tangible, achievable first steps. The most complicated problems are often solved with a series of painfully simple steps. Achieving "easy wins" helps build momentum and reduces the feeling of being overwhelmed. Early steps could include having a discovery conversation about potential solutions or testing a new tool with a select team. Each step should be designed to lead to the next, creating a steady path toward transformation.

By aligning goals with the firm's vision, prioritizing what truly matters, and involving your team, you'll create OKRs and KPIs that resonate and drive action. For mid-sized law firms, this structured approach ensures that every objective moves the firm closer to its strategic ambitions, fosters accountability, and inspires your team to work toward shared success.

4 Resistance to change (R)

Resistance often stems from inertia—the fear of moving from a familiar state to an unfamiliar one. By understanding the psychological and strategic factors that drive resistance to change, leaders can proactively address them and set the stage for a successful transformation. Through cultivating dissatisfaction with the current state, crafting a compelling vision for the future, and taking manageable first steps, law firms can overcome resistance and embrace change that benefits both the firm and its clients.

When applying the Change Equation, if any of the factors (Dissatisfaction, Vision, or First Steps) is weak or missing, the result will be zero, and resistance will not be overcome. That's why it's crucial to have a strong commitment to all three components to drive change.

Before we dive into Part 2, here's where the Change Equation really starts to click. When something's not working—when change is stalling or people are resisting—it's tempting to jump to tactics. But real traction comes when you go deeper. That's why I often ask my clients to go five levels down—keep asking "why?" until you uncover what's truly driving (or blocking) change. Because when you get to the root of the *D* (dissatisfaction), the *V* (vision), the *F* (first steps), or the *R* (resistance), you unlock real power. That's where lasting change starts—not with surface-level fixes, but with a clear understanding of what's really going on.

Embracing change—what to expect after you start

The Change Equation—Dissatisfaction x Vision x First Steps > Resistance—highlights how dissatisfaction with current practices, a compelling vision for the future, and tangible first steps can collectively overcome resistance. Once your firm takes those first steps, it's worth taking a moment to recognize what progress towards real, impactful change looks like.

The change management process often comes with its own challenges to manage and overcome. The concept of the Change Curve illustrates some of these challenges, particularly the emotional responses that your team may experience during a period of change.

The Change Curve is divided into three main stages:

- **Stage 1:** This initial stage is characterized by **shock** and **denial.** Even if your team has been involved in creating a vision for change and those first steps, when a change is first introduced, individuals may experience a sense of shock or disbelief. They might deny the need for change or its potential impact. During this stage, **performance typically sees an initial dip** as people process the news and resist acknowledging the new reality.
- **Stage 2:** As the initial shock and denial subside, individuals move into Stage 2, which involves **Anger** and **Depression.** Resistance becomes more active, and people may feel frustrated, resentful, or angry about the change. This can lead to a significant decline in morale, and **performance may drop even further.** Feelings of loss and uncertainty can contribute to a sense of depression or disengagement.
- **Stage 3:** The final stage of the Change Curve involves **Acceptance** and **Integration.** As individuals begin to understand and accept the change, they start to adjust and find ways to work within the new environment. **Performance gradually begins to recover and eventually integrates at a new level.** People start to embrace the changes and may even see the potential benefits.

These stages aren't optional—they're part of the human experience of change, much like the cycles of grief. Everyone goes through them. Some move quickly. Others get stuck in Stage 1 or 2, or even slide backwards when the pressure builds. That's why effective leaders don't try to force people forward. They stay curious. They ask why someone might be resisting, and look for the unmet needs underneath. Often, simply recognizing a person's natural tendency to ask, "*What's in it for me?*" can unlock a path forward. When you see these stages for what they are—predictable, human responses—you can meet people where they are, guide them through the tough parts, and help them move toward acceptance, performance, and lasting change.

Clio's solutions as drivers of change

Change can be challenging—but it's also necessary for mid-sized law firms that want to stay competitive, efficient, and client-focused. Clio's suite of legal practice management tools is purpose-built to make that transformation easier, more strategic, and more successful.

By addressing the most common barriers to change—manual processes, inefficiencies, and lack of visibility—Clio helps law firms move forward with confidence. Whether it's streamlining operations, improving team accountability, or enhancing the client experience, Clio offers the technology and guidance firms need to turn their goals into action.

With Clio as your partner, your firm is equipped not just to adapt, but to lead—building a future that's more efficient, resilient, and ready for growth. Here's how Clio's solutions help address the challenges outlined in this guide and drive meaningful transformation:

1. **Clio Manage:** By centralizing firm operations and automating workflows, Clio Manage eliminates inefficiencies like manual data entry and redundant tasks. It transforms disorganized processes into streamlined operations, which directly addresses dissatisfaction and reduces friction within the firm. Every member of your firm, from partners to paralegals, will find value in optimizing their daily tasks with Clio Manage.
2. **Clio Grow:** Clio Grow improves client intake and communication by automating your most tedious client intake tasks. It saves time for both clients and staff, easing frustrations with outdated, inefficient systems. By improving client interactions from the outset, it sets a positive tone for the entire client experience.
3. **Clio Duo:** Clio Duo is your firm's AI-powered partner, built to reduce the burden of repetitive, time-consuming tasks. By automating workflows like drafting communications, summarizing documents, and surfacing key information instantly, it helps your team focus on strategic, high-value work. Clio Duo transforms how legal professionals interact with information—turning complex inputs into clear, actionable insights—so your firm can work smarter, faster, and with greater confidence.
4. **Clio Draft:** Document automation through Clio Draft saves time and reduces errors, addressing dissatisfaction with repetitive tasks. It ensures that your team can focus on more strategic work, contributing to the broader vision of a more efficient firm.

When you adopt Clio tools, you're not in it alone. We recognize that change is hard, and we're here to provide award-winning migration and onboarding support to ensure a smooth transition. When you make the move to Clio you'll also receive a custom migration plan, onboarding support for your entire firm, dedicated Customer Success Manager*, and personalized recommendations to ensure firm adoption.

In addition to these tools, Clio supports change management with resources like the *Managing Change at Your Law Firm* resource hub, offering frameworks, best practices, and expert guidance.

Real-world insights from Koenig|Dunne

Koenig|Dunne, a 20-employee Omaha-based Divorce firm, has firsthand experience applying change management principles with their team. Their insights offer valuable, real-world guidance for mid-sized law firms looking to implement effective change strategies.

Strategic rollout with test groups

Angela Lennon, Partner and COO, and Michaela Seidl, Advanced Certified Paralegal and Paralegal Manager, at Koenig|Dunne both emphasize the effectiveness of beginning change initiatives with a test group of team members who are most receptive to new changes. This approach allows firms to identify potential issues early on and develop best practices before a broader rollout. Michaela also highlights the importance of including individuals who may be more resistant to change. By bringing in those who are hesitant, firms can gain valuable insights into potential barriers and better address concerns from all angles.

Addressing resistance through open dialogue and curiosity

At Koenig|Dunne resistance is met with active listening and a genuine effort to understand the underlying concerns. In one case, Angela was herself initially resistant to adopting electronic draft reviews at the firm. As the one resistant to change herself, she participated in the team dialogue to articulate potential challenges, and to ultimately help shape a compelling vision for how to move forward and overcome perceived hurdles. Through patient, open dialogue and curiosity, the team worked together to uncover what was truly getting in the way. It is through this process that teams can better address concerns and foster a more receptive environment for change.

Navigating common sticking points with empathy and transparency

Fear of incompetence, especially when learning new technologies or processes, is a major barrier to change. Michaela notes that "people don't want to feel stupid." Additionally, worries about job security due to automation or the ingrained mindset of "this is the way we've always done it" can significantly hinder progress. To address these concerns, it's essential to create a safe space for open dialogue. Transparent communication about the rationale behind the changes and addressing potential fears head-on is key to overcoming these barriers and building trust.

Understanding the personal connection: "What's in it for me?" (WIIFM)

Change initiatives must clearly articulate the personal benefits for each team member. Everyone is motivated by their own needs and priorities, which is why it's crucial to ask: What's in it for me? This question serves as the filter through which team members evaluate change. By framing the change in terms of individual benefits—such as less time spent on administrative tasks or more efficient workflows—leaders can increase buy-in and support.

Setting SMART goals for focused implementation

Koenig|Dunne employs a goal-oriented approach to change. When introducing new systems or processes, defining **SMART** goals—**S**pecific, **M**easurable, **A**chievable, **R**ealistic, and **T**imely—provides clarity and ensures progress can be tracked. For example, implementing a new client intake system might involve setting specific metrics for success, such as reducing intake time by 30% over a three-month period. This structured approach ensures that the impact of change can be clearly evaluated and adjusted if necessary.

Leveraging the valuable insights of paralegals

Michaela = emphasizes the invaluable role of paralegals in the feedback loop. Since paralegals "touch so many pieces of the firm," their insights into the practicality and impact of changes are critical. Actively seeking their feedback helps ensure that changes are practical and effective across different roles in the firm.

Fostering psychological safety through culture and communication

Angela underscores the importance of creating a culture where continuous improvement is embraced by everyone. Transparent communication from leadership about the reasons behind changes is crucial for building psychological safety and trust. A culture that encourages open feedback, acknowledges challenges, and adjusts when necessary creates a strong foundation for navigating change effectively. Additionally, recognizing when the team is experiencing change fatigue and adjusting the pace of implementation can help maintain momentum without overwhelming the team.

Koenig|Dunne's approach offers a comprehensive roadmap for law firms looking to implement change effectively. By starting small with test groups, fostering open dialogue, setting clear goals, and prioritizing psychological safety, law firms can navigate resistance and drive meaningful transformation within their organizations.

Sustaining continuous improvement

Change is not a one-time event; it's a continuous journey that requires a commitment to ongoing improvement and adaptation. To successfully sustain change, law firms must foster a culture of learning, responsiveness, and client-centered focus.

The impact of leadership style on change adoption

Leadership style plays a critical role in the success of change initiatives. Different approaches can either facilitate or hinder the adoption of change. A **coaching** or **affiliative** leadership style—one that is supportive, empathetic, and focuses on building relationships—tends to make change easier and more sustainable. In contrast, **pacesetting** or **coercive** leadership styles, which emphasize high expectations and control, may lead to short-term compliance but are less effective over time and can create resistance. Leaders should be mindful of their style and adapt it to encourage buy-in and foster a smoother transition.[2]

Implementing after-action reviews for learning and growth

The **After-Action Review (AAR)** is a valuable tool for reflecting on the successes and challenges of change initiatives. By asking four key questions, firms can assess the impact of the change and learn from both successes and setbacks:

- *What did we expect to happen?*
- *What actually happened?*
- *What was different, and why was it different?*
- *What do we do differently next time?*

The focus should be on objective analysis and identifying areas for future growth, not on assigning blame. AARs create opportunities for continuous learning, allowing firms to adapt and improve their processes over time.[3]

[2] D. Goleman, Leadership That Gets Results. (Boston: Harvard Business Review, 2000).
[3] D. Collie, Winning Under Fire: Turn Stress into Success the U.S. Army Way. (New York: McGraw-Hill, 2004).

Maintaining client trust and satisfaction during times of change

Many changes within law firms are implemented with the goal of improving client service. However, periods of transition—such as attorney turnover or the introduction of new systems—can create uncertainty for clients. It's essential to have a clear strategy in place and proactively communicate with clients to alleviate concerns. Clients need to understand that the firm is committed to maintaining the same high standards of service during times of change.

In addition to communication, it's important to set realistic expectations regarding response times. Framing these expectations by explaining that when a lawyer is focused on a client's legal matter, they need uninterrupted time to give it the proper attention. This approach ensures clients feel valued while also maintaining a level of service that is consistent with their needs.

Empowering change: How technology and strategy drive success in mid-sized law firms

Achieving meaningful and sustainable change in a mid-sized law firm is an ongoing journey, not a one-time event. It requires a thoughtful approach that navigates the natural resistance to change, inspires a clear vision for the future, and breaks down the process into practical, manageable steps. By applying the principles of the Change Equation, leveraging insights from real-world examples like Koenig|Dunne, and committing to continuous improvement through tools such as after-action reviews, law firms can effectively respond to challenges in today's rapidly evolving legal landscape.

The key to success lies in understanding the "why" behind change—clearly communicating it to your team and clients, and aligning your firm's technology with these goals. By fostering a culture of transparency, adaptability, and learning, law firms can not only overcome resistance but drive lasting, positive transformation. With Clio's suite of solutions as a strategic partner, your firm can streamline processes, enhance client service, and build a stronger, more efficient foundation for future growth.

Driving change with Clio: A partner in transformation

Embracing change is essential for mid-sized law firms that want to thrive. To overcome this resistance and achieve meaningful transformation, the right technology is critical—and Clio's suite of legal practice management solutions plays a key role in making that change easier and more effective.

By strategically leveraging Clio's technology and resources, mid-sized law firms can address the challenges that fuel resistance to change, build a compelling vision for a more efficient, client-centered future, and take clear, concrete steps toward achieving their goals.

Just as you rely on advisors to help simplify complex decisions, Clio serves as a trusted partner, guiding law firms through the process of change with technology that makes transformation easier, faster, and more impactful.

Glossary of key terms and concepts

Resistance to change: The natural response to change, often driven by mental models such as fear of the unknown, perfectionism, and risk aversion. Common contributing factors include precedent preference, fear of loss, FUD (Fear, Uncertainty, and Doubt), people-pleasing, shiny object syndrome, and change fatigue.

The Change Equation: A formula illustrating the conditions necessary for successful change. It consists of **Dissatisfaction (D)**, **Vision (V)**, and **First Steps (F)**, with their multiplication overcoming **Resistance (R)**: $D \times V \times F > R$.

SMART goals: A framework for setting clear, actionable goals during change initiatives: **Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Realistic,** and **Timely**. SMART goals help track progress and ensure focus on the desired outcomes.

WIIFM (What's in it for me?): The personal benefit or perceived advantage an individual believes they will gain from adopting a particular change. WIIFM is critical in gaining buy-in from team members.

Tips and traps in change management: Recognizing the counterproductivity of excessive time pressure on creativity, understanding **WIIFM** for team members, clarifying the **Why** behind change (Simon Sinek's approach), and adapting leadership culture and style to facilitate smoother transitions.

After-action reviews: A structured process for evaluating change initiatives. It involves asking what was expected, what actually happened, what was different, and how to improve in the future. The focus is on objective learning rather than assigning blame.

Psychological safety: Creating an environment where team members feel comfortable taking risks, voicing concerns, and learning from mistakes—essential for effective change, especially during challenging transitions.

Change fatigue: The exhaustion and resistance that result from undergoing too many organizational changes in a short period, leading to diminished engagement and productivity.

FUD (Fear, Uncertainty, and Doubt): A set of anxieties that contribute to resistance to change, particularly when outcomes are unknown or unclear. FUD can cause hesitation and delay in decision-making.

Mental models: Deep-seated beliefs and assumptions that influence how individuals perceive and interpret the world. These models often shape reactions to change, with entrenched mental models being a significant barrier to adoption.

Perfectionism: The tendency to strive for flawlessness and set excessively high standards, which can hinder the adoption of new processes and technologies due to a fear of making mistakes.

Clio is the world's leading provider of cloud-based legal technology, providing lawyers with low-barrier, affordable solutions to manage and grow their firms more effectively, more profitably, and with better client experiences. It redefines how lawyers manage their firms by equipping them with the tools they need to run their firms securely from any device, anywhere.

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